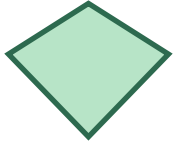


Sensory-Friendly Meal Planner & Grocery Guide



A clean, calming, TEACCH-inspired planner that helps neurodiverse families reduce mealtime stress, plan balanced weeks, and shop predictably.

Educational resource. For ARFID or growth concerns, consult your clinician.

How to Use This (One-Minute Overview)

Step	What to do
1. Sensory Profile	Fill textures/temps/flavors your child enjoys. Use it to guide weekly menus.
2. Weekly Plan	Mix preferred “ safe ” foods with one low-pressure exposure each day.
3. Visual Grocery	Print the checklist. Follow your store route to minimize sensory load.
4. Food-Chaining Map	Move from accepted → similar → target foods (texture first).

Why this planner works (evidence in brief)



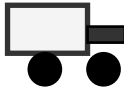
Visual supports & schedules improve independence and reduce anxiety for autistic learners across settings.



Low-pressure food exposure and systematic desensitization increase acceptance in autism-related selectivity.



Food Chaining grows variety by changing one property at a time (texture/temperature/taste/color).



Predictable grocery routes and reduced sensory load support successful store trips.

Sensory Profile (fill-able)

Dimension	Like	Tolerate	Avoid	Notes
Texture (crunchy, smooth, mixed, chewy, stringy)				
Temperature (cold, room, warm, hot)				
Flavor (sweet, savory, sour, bitter, spicy)				
Color/Appearance (plain, beige, colorful, sauces)				
Smell (strong vs mild)				

Weekly Meal Plan (calm layout)

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snack(s)	Today's low■pressure exposure
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					

Food-Chaining Map (template + example)

Accepted	Small change 1	Small change 2	Small change 3	Target
Chicken nuggets	Breaded fish sticks	Baked fish sticks	Baked fish (light sea food)	Cooked fish

Visual Grocery List (icons + checkboxes)

Produce	☐ Apples ☐ Bananas ☐ Berries ☐ Carrots ☐ Cucumbers ☐ Lettuce ☐ Potatoes
Protein	☐ Chicken ☐ Eggs ☐ Beans/Lentils ☐ Fish ☐ Tofu/Tempeh
Dairy/Calcium	☐ Milk ☐ Yogurt ☐ Cheese ☐ Fortified alt ☐ milk
Grains	☐ Bread ☐ Tortillas ☐ Rice ☐ Pasta ☐ Oats ☐ Crackers
Pantry	☐ Oil ☐ Broth ☐ Mild spices ☐ Applesauce ☐ Canned fruit/veg
Freezer	☐ Frozen fruit/veg ☐ Fish sticks ☐ Chicken tenders ☐ Peas/Corn

Starter Recipes (family-style, sensory-aware)

Crispy Baked Fish Bites (Food-Chaining from Nuggets)

Serves 4 • 25 min

Ingredients	Steps
• 1 lb mild white fish (cod/pollock), cut into 1-inch pieces • 1 cup panko or crushed cornflakes • 1 egg + 1 tbsp water, whisked • 1 tbsp oil • Salt/pepper to taste (optional)	1) Heat oven to 425 ° F (220 ° C). Line tray; brush with oil. 2) Dip fish in egg, then panko. Place on tray; drizzle remaining oil. 2) Bake 10 – 12 min, turning once until crisp and opaque. 2) Serve with ketchup or yogurt dip alongside a preferred starch.

Why it helps: Crunchy texture and finger-food format mimic nuggets while introducing fish; gradual texture shift supports acceptance.

Pasta 50/50 (White + Whole-Grain Blend)

Serves 4 • 20 min

Ingredients	Steps
• 4 cups dry pasta (50% white, 50% whole-grain) • 1 cup smooth marinara (or butter/olive oil if preferred) • Parmesan (optional)	1) Boil both pastas together until tender. 2) Toss with smooth sauce or butter/olive oil. 2) Keep textures simple; offer cheese on the side.

Why it helps: Maintains familiar taste while incrementally increasing fiber/texture complexity.

Sheet-Pan Chicken & Carrots (Low-Smell, Low-Noise)

Serves 4 • 30 min

Ingredients	Steps
• 1 lb chicken tenders • 3 cups carrot sticks • 2 tbsp olive oil • 1 tsp mild seasoning (garlic powder or none) • Salt to taste	1) Heat oven to 425 ° F. 2) Toss all with oil and seasoning. 2) Roast 18 – 22 min, flipping once. 2) Serve separated on plate (no foods touching) if preferred.

Why it helps: Predictable shapes and separated plating reduce sensory load; roasting minimizes loud sizzling/smell versus pan-frying.

Yogurt Fruit Smoothie (Cold, Smooth, Neutral Color)

Serves 2 • 5 min

Ingredients	Steps
• 1 cup plain or vanilla yogurt • 1 cup frozen berries or banana • 1/2 – 1 cup milk/alt-milk	1) Blend to ultra-smooth. 2) Offer in covered straw cup if visual color is a barrier.

Why it helps: Uniform cold/smooth texture reduces mixed-texture aversion; straw cup can dampen smell/visual stimuli.

Advantages of this meal prep system

- **Less overwhelm:** calm visuals, predictable routines, fewer last-minute decisions.
- **Better acceptance:** low-pressure exposure + food chaining increase variety over time.
- **Easier shopping:** icon list + route planning reduce sensory triggers in stores.
- **Family alignment:** DOR roles end power struggles and support self-regulation.

References (supporting the approach & recipes)

See product listing for direct links: visual supports; food exposure/desensitization; Food Chaining; Division of Responsibility; ARFID; sensory-inclusive supermarkets.